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Playing It a Bit Cooler (1965–1968)

> *There is no difference in the object of containing China. The difference is only how we can achieve it. We feel America is going in the wrong way.*
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> — M. C. Chagla, Indian foreign minister, 1967[1]

In the aftermath of the 1965 war, on a phone call with US ambassador to the UN Arthur Goldberg, Lyndon Johnson ranted about India's priorities and its performance. When Goldberg suggested that the US should just let India "go communist," Johnson stopped him, noting, "I don't know, that's what they said Acheson did with China."[2] And, in the president's mind, Truman had had to suffer the negative strategic and political consequences of China's loss. He could not similarly "lose" India; it was too big to fail. And despite frustration with Johnson, for India, the external and internal threat that China posed meant that the US remained too important to jettison as a partner.

Mutual need kept the US and India tethered to each other, but the bonds were fraying. The war had only added to the growing disappointment on both sides. Over the next three years, the disappointment would turn to disillusionment. As the US became more involved in Vietnam, Johnson increasingly questioned India's capacity and willingness to play the role that US policymakers needed it to play in Asia vis-à-vis China. His disillusionment led to disinterest, reinforced by the fact that, while